

Hedonic adaptation is a person's tendency to return to a relatively stable level of happiness after adapting to major events or life changes, be they positive or negative. When we have a new and pleasurable experience, it makes us happier . . . for a short while. Then we adapt, returning to our baseline level of happiness. This leads to needing the next thing, then the next, and the one after that to make us happy—temporarily. For some, this ongoing loop becomes necessary just to stay happy. This phenomenon is referred to as the “hedonic treadmill.”

I was guilty of falling into this pattern with cable TV for years. My wife would get irritated when paying the cable bill and seeing little rate hikes of \$2 here and \$5 there. This happened every few months. She kept suggesting that we get rid of cable.

The sports lover in me was unwilling to change. How would I watch my teams? How would I function at work when everyone was talking about sports and news all day? We all have our limits, and this was mine. Having hundreds of channels of sports, news, and entertainment at my fingertips year after year was my normal. I viewed it as a necessity.

Once I got serious about FI, I started paying closer attention to our spending. Then I started challenging my wife on different things.